


Left: **Lev Landau, as a student in Leningrad in the mid-1920s.** ***Right:*** **Landau, with fellow physics students George Gamow and Yevgenia Kanegiesser, horsing around in the midst of their studies in Leningrad, ca. 1927. In reality, Landau never played any musical instrument.** [Left: courtesy AlP Emilio Segre Visual Archives, Margarethe Bohr Collection; right: courtesy Library of Congress.]

A fellow postdoctoral student in Zurich, German-born Rudolph Peierls, later wrote, “I vividly remember the great impression Landau made on all of us when he appeared in Wolfgang Pauli’s department in Zurich in 1929.¼ It did not take long to discover the depth of his understanding of modern physics, and his skill in solving basic problems. He rarely read a paper on theoretical physics in detail, but looked at it long enough to see whether the problem was interesting, and if so, what was the author’s approach. He then set to work to do the calculation himself, and if the answer agreed with the author’s he approved of the paper.” Peierls and Landau became the best of friends.

Tall, skinny, intensely critical of others as well as himself, Landau despaired that he had been born a few years too late. The golden age of physics, he thought, had been 1925–27 when de Broglie, Schrödinger, Heisenberg, Bohr, and others were creating the new quantum mechanics; if born earlier, he, Landau, could have been a participant. “All the nice girls